Haligric Research Integration Series

Peoples of Cedar and Salt Water

A COMPLETE DEEP DIVE

The Sacred Traditions of the Tlingit, Haida, Tsimshian, Kwakwaka'wakw, Nuu-chah-nulth, and Coast Salish Nations

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Along the fjords and rainforests of the Northwest Coast — from the Alaskan panhandle down through British Columbia and into Puget Sound — a constellation of nations built one of the richest ceremonial civilizations north of Mexico without ever taking up agriculture.

Wealth here was measured in what a person gave away, not what they kept. A single song could outvalue a mountain of blankets. A cedar plank house could hold four hundred guests through a winter of dance.

This is the world of the potlatch and the Hamatsa, of Raven who stole the light and Sisiutl the two-headed serpent, of moieties older than memory and canoes still pulled today in the same cold water their ancestors crossed.

It survived a law built to erase it.

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Introduction — Peoples of Cedar and Salt Water

The Pacific Northwest Coast stretches roughly two thousand miles, from the Copper River delta in southern Alaska down through the islands and inlets of British Columbia to the Olympic Peninsula and Puget Sound in Washington State. Within this narrow, rain-soaked strip of temperate rainforest and cold, salmon-rich water live dozens of distinct nations, commonly grouped by outsiders under names such as Tlingit, Haida, Tsimshian, Haisla, Heiltsuk, Kwakwaka'wakw (formerly called Kwakiutl), Nuu-chah-nulth (formerly Nootka), and the many Coast Salish peoples of the southern coast and Puget Sound, including the Squamish, Musqueam, Lummi, and Suquamish.

These nations never developed agriculture, yet they built some of the most materially and ceremonially elaborate societies in North America — permanent cedar-plank villages, oceangoing canoes carved from single red cedar logs, and a class-stratified social order of hereditary chiefs, nobles, commoners, and, in the historic period, enslaved war captives. The material basis for all of it was the overwhelming abundance of salmon, halibut, oolichan (candlefish), shellfish, and cedar itself — a tree so central to daily and spiritual life that it is often called the "tree of life" of the coast.

What unites these otherwise linguistically and politically distinct nations is not a shared religion in the sense of a single pantheon, but a shared ceremonial grammar: matrilineal or patrilineal clan systems organized around inherited crests, an economy of prestige built on the potlatch, a winter ceremonial season when the ordinary world gives way to the supernatural one, and a conviction that wealth exists to be given away, not hoarded.

Origins and the Time of Transformation

Archaeological evidence places continuous human occupation of the Northwest Coast at ten thousand years and older, with some coastal and island sites — including on Haida Gwaii — suggesting habitation stretching back to the end of the last Ice Age, when lower sea levels exposed a coastal migration route now submerged.

Within the oral traditions themselves, origin is rarely a single creation event. Most nations tell instead of a Transformer or Trickster figure — Raven among the Tlingit, Haida, Tsimshian, and Kwakwaka'wakw; Xa:ls among many Coast Salish peoples — who moved through a formless or animal-dominated early world, fixing its features into their present form: setting rivers in their courses, teaching the first humans to fish and weave cedar, and in the best-known Raven story, stealing the sun, moon, and stars from a sky chief who had hoarded them in boxes, and releasing light into the world for the first time.

Flood narratives also recur widely along the coast, describing an ancient deluge that scattered or transformed the ancestors of present clans, after which survivors descended from the mountaintops that had sheltered them and refounded the villages — a narrative that anchors specific clan crests and territorial rights to specific geographic features still pointed to today.

Cosmology and the Spirit World

Northwest Coast cosmology, particularly as documented among the Kwakwaka'wakw, generally recognizes four interpenetrating spirit realms: the sky world, the sea world, the earth world, and an otherworldly or ghost realm. These are not remote heavens but active, nearby domains whose inhabitants regularly cross into human life, especially during the winter ceremonial season, when the membrane between the human and spirit worlds is at its thinnest.

Raven (Yéil to the Tlingit, Wéigyet or Txaamsm to the Tsimshian, ’U’melth to the Kwakwaka'wakw) is at once creator, culture hero, and insatiable trickster — the figure who brought fire, salmon, fresh water, and daylight to human beings, often through theft or deception rather than benevolence.

Thunderbird is lord of the winter dance season and of the sky realm: an immense supernatural bird whose wingbeats produce thunder and whose blinking eyes throw lightning, said to be powerful enough to hunt whales by diving from the clouds.

Kumugwe (also called Komokwa), the Undersea Chief, rules the wealth of the ocean depths — coppers, sea otters, and supernatural treasures — and grants prosperity to families he favors.

Sisiutl is a two- or three-headed sea serpent of immense power, able to petrify enemies with a glance and to transform itself into a self-paddling war canoe or a protective belt worn by warriors; its image appears carved on housefronts and canoes as a mark of both danger and protection.

Dzunukwa (Tsonokwa) is a giant of the deep forest, appearing in both male and female forms, most often depicted as a black-skinned, hollow-eyed, child-stealing ogress whose low moaning cry — "uu, uu" — lures the unwary; paradoxically she also owns great supernatural wealth that can be won from her by the clever or the brave.

Bakwas, King of the Ghosts, is a skeletal green-faced spirit of the drowned and the lost, who tempts the living toward the land of the dead with offerings of ghost food.

The Hamatsa cannibal spirits — chief among them Baxwbakwalanuksiwe', 'Cannibal-at-the-North-End-of-the-World' — possess hereditary dancers during the most sacred of all winter ceremonies, dramatizing a controlled descent into and return from a state of ritual wildness.

Clans, Crests, and the Moiety System

Among the Tlingit and Haida, all of society is divided into two reciprocal halves, or moieties: Raven and Eagle (in some Tlingit clans, Wolf stands in for Eagle). Every person belongs to one moiety for life, inherited matrilineally — through the mother's line — regardless of a father's affiliation. Marriage is expected to occur across moiety lines, and the opposite moiety provides essential ceremonial labor at funerals, potlatches, and other major rites, since a person's own moiety cannot perform these services for them.

Within each moiety are smaller clans, whose members trace descent to a shared ancestor and hold specific crests — stylized animal images such as Wolf, Killer Whale, Frog, or Beaver — displayed on totem poles, house fronts, canoes, blankets, and at.óowu (ceremonial regalia). These crests are property in the fullest sense: they can be won, lost, loaned, or transferred through marriage and potlatch, and using another clan's crest without right is a serious social offense.

The Kwakwaka'wakw and Nuu-chah-nulth systems differ in detail — descent and privilege can pass through either parent and numaym (extended kin groups headed by a chief) organize social life rather than strict moieties — but the underlying logic is the same: rank, name, territory, and supernatural privilege are hereditary property, publicly validated only when displayed and witnessed at a potlatch.

The Potlatch — Ceremony as Law

The word potlatch comes from the Chinook Jargon term for "to give," and it names both a single feast and the entire redistributive economic-legal-spiritual system built around it. Where many economies measure status by accumulation, Northwest Coast societies measured it by generosity: a chief's standing rested on how much he could give away, not how much he could keep.

A potlatch marks essentially every major transition in social life: the naming of a child, the raising of a totem or house pole, a marriage, the transfer of a chieftainship, the settlement of a debt, and above all the mourning of the dead, since a deceased chief's rank and property cannot formally pass to an heir until it has been validated at a memorial potlatch. Historically these gatherings could last for weeks through the winter months, held in massive cedar bighouses whose size itself signaled the host's rank, and drawing guests from allied nations who arrived by canoe.

Guests are not passive recipients; they are witnesses, whose acceptance of gifts constitutes their public acknowledgment of the host family's claims — to a name, a crest, a territory, a story. Gifts themselves evolved with contact: eighteenth- and nineteenth-century potlatches gave furs, canoes, and cedar-bark blankets; the Hudson's Bay Company era added wool blankets, flour, and copper bracelets; contemporary potlatches often distribute practical goods alongside crest-marked art.

Above ordinary gifts stood the copper: a shield-shaped sheet of beaten copper, each one individually named, with its own history and an assigned value reckoned in blankets — the most famous coppers were said to be worth thousands of blankets apiece, and only high-ranking chiefs could own or break one, an act of supreme, deliberate destruction of wealth to assert unmatched status. Above even the copper stood the song: inherited within a family line and considered so valuable that, as Kwakwaka'wakw tradition holds, no quantity of blankets, however high the pile, can equal the worth of a single song.

The Hamatsa and the Winter Ceremonial Season

Among the Kwakwaka'wakw, the winter months — when subsistence labor slows and the spirit world draws close — are given over to the tseka, or winter ceremonial dances, organized through hereditary secret societies. The most sacred and highest-ranking of these is the Hamatsa, whose dancers are understood to be possessed by Baxwbakwalanuksiwe', the great cannibal spirit of the north end of the world.

A Hamatsa initiation unfolds in carefully staged phases. It opens with the sound of hidden whistles (madzis) representing the cannibal spirit moving through the forest toward the bighouse; the initiate then enters wearing hemlock-bough regalia, wild and barely controllable, attended by a hiligaxste', a female relative whose role is to calm him. Attendants strip away the hemlock and dress him instead in red-dyed cedar bark, the mark of his transformation, and he dances around the central fire to three ceremonial songs. At the height of the rite he cries out and retreats behind a carved dance screen, from behind which come the sounds of Hamsamł, the cannibal bird spirits, and masked dancers representing Huxwhukw and Galukwamł emerge to dance in the corners of the house, their bodies wrapped in shredded cedar bark.

The ceremony resolves with the initiate's return, now calm, wrapped in a chief's blanket and led by his attendant, at which point other hereditary Hamatsa members of his family join him to formally welcome the newest member of the society. Historically, a novice might withdraw into the forest for as long as four months before this culminating rite; contemporary Hamatsa ceremonies compress this period considerably while preserving its ritual structure and meaning.

The house posts, painted dance screens, whistles, and elaborately hinged transformation masks used in these ceremonies are themselves considered to hold supernatural power and are treated as sacred property, passed down and reactivated at each performance rather than created new.

Key Figures Who Carried and Defended the Tradition

Chief Dan Cranmer, a Kwakwaka'wakw leader, hosted what became the single most consequential potlatch in the ban era: a six-day gathering at ’Mimkwa̱mlis on Village Island in December 1921, attended by roughly three hundred people. Canadian authorities charged forty-five participants; about half served two- to three-month jail terms, while the rest avoided prison by surrendering roughly six hundred ceremonial objects — masks, coppers, regalia — that were dispersed to museums in Ottawa, Toronto, New York, and the United Kingdom, or sold into private hands.

Chief Mungo Martin, a master carver and ceremonialist, held the first fully legal potlatch since 1885 in Victoria, British Columbia, in 1953, following the 1951 repeal of the ban, and did enormous work training a new generation of carvers and passing on ceremonial knowledge that had gone underground for decades.

Chief Willie Seaweed, another major Kwakwaka'wakw carver and ceremonial leader, is widely credited with keeping potlatch traditions and Hamatsa knowledge alive through the years of prohibition, continuing to hold clandestine ceremonies at real legal risk.

Franz Boas, the German-American anthropologist often called the father of American anthropology, spent decades documenting Kwakwaka'wakw language, myth, and ceremony beginning in the 1880s; he publicly opposed the potlatch ban and hosted potlatches himself in a show of solidarity, though his relationship to the material he extracted and the museum collections it fed remains a subject of ongoing, legitimate criticism from descendant communities.

Bill Reid, a Haida artist of the twentieth century, is credited with sparking a broad renaissance in Northwest Coast formline art and jewelry that carried crest imagery and carving traditions into international galleries and public monuments, most famously his sculpture The Spirit of Haida Gwaii.

Contemporary culture-bearers — including hereditary chiefs, master carvers such as Robert Davidson (Haida) and dance group leaders across Kwakwaka'wakw, Tlingit, and Coast Salish nations, and organizations like the U'mista Cultural Centre in Alert Bay, founded specifically to repatriate and house potlatch items confiscated in 1921 — continue this line of transmission today.

Self-Care, Wellness, and Daily Practice

Modern Tribal Canoe Journeys are the clearest living expression of Northwest Coast wellness practice today. The tradition traces to the 1989 "Paddle to Seattle," organized by Quinault elder Emmett Oliver as part of Washington State's centennial, when a flotilla of roughly forty canoes landed at Golden Gardens Park in Seattle. Oliver's dream of a hundred-canoe landing was realized in 2012 at the Paddle to Squaxin, when 103 canoes arrived; by the 2020s the annual journey routinely draws well over a hundred canoe families from nations across the coast and as far as New Zealand.

Canoe families travel for days or weeks along traditional water routes, stopping at host communities where crews formally request permission to come ashore — a living potlatch protocol — before days of shared meals, songs, dances, and gifts. Canoes themselves are treated as living relatives rather than equipment; as one elder has put it, the wood of the canoe carries the presence of ancestors, "Grandma and Grandpa," so paddling is itself an act of relationship, not merely transport.

The journeys are explicitly understood as healing work. Philip H. Red Eagle and other canoe leaders describe them as a deliberate "return to culture" for communities recovering from generations of forced assimilation, and sobriety is a formal, non-negotiable condition of participation — no drugs or alcohol are permitted on the water or at camp, making the canoe journey one of the coast's primary contemporary vehicles for substance-abuse recovery and youth mentorship. The public-health program Healing of the Canoe, developed by the Suquamish and Port Gamble S'Klallam tribes with the University of Washington, formalizes this connection directly, using canoe-journey values and traditional teachings as a structured substance-abuse prevention curriculum for Native youth.

Alongside the canoe journeys, everyday and ceremonial wellness practices on the coast have historically included ritual bathing in cold water or the ocean for purification and spiritual strengthening, the use of cedar boughs and cedar-bark for smudging, cleansing, and regalia, and an extensive pharmacopeia of coastal plants — including devil's club, used across many nations as a treatment for pain, inflammation, and as a spiritual protective medicine, and yarrow, western red cedar, and stinging nettle, used for a range of physical ailments — administered by knowledge-holders whose training combined herbal expertise with spiritual authority.

Ceremonial Wood — Totem and House Poles

The carved monumental poles popularly called "totem poles" are more precisely crest poles, memorial poles, or house-front poles, each raised for a specific documented purpose: to record a family's inherited crests and the stories that justify their right to them, to mark a chief's death and his successor's assumption of rank, to commemorate a historic event, or to shame a rival who has failed to repay a debt (a genuine "shame pole" tradition, now largely historical).

Reading a pole correctly requires knowing the specific family history it encodes; the figures are not a hierarchy of importance stacked bottom-to-top, as the popular phrase "low man on the totem pole" wrongly implies, but a sequence of crest images — Raven, Eagle, Killer Whale, Grizzly Bear, Thunderbird — whose order and combination is unique to the pole's owning family and the specific story or right being asserted.

Raising a pole is itself a potlatch occasion, requiring a feast, witnesses, and the public payment of the carvers, who are understood to be exercising both artistic skill and inherited or granted spiritual authority in shaping the wood. In the twentieth century, the mass removal of poles from village sites to museums and private collections — often under pressure, deception, or outright theft — became one of the coast's most significant and still unresolved losses, and pole-raising today doubles as a visible act of cultural reassertion, with new poles going up in cities, universities, and former mission and residential school sites.

Legacy and Influence

Northwest Coast formline art — the flowing, ovoid-and-U-form design language used on poles, masks, canoes, and regalia — is now recognized internationally as one of the major visual art traditions of the world, exhibited in institutions from the American Museum of Natural History to the Musée du quai Branly, and its principles are taught formally in university art programs such as the University of Washington's survey of Native Northwest Coast art.

The successful, decades-long repatriation campaigns led by Kwakwaka'wakw communities and institutions such as the U'mista Cultural Centre — founded in 1980 specifically to recover the ceremonial items seized after the 1921 Cranmer potlatch — became an influential model for Indigenous repatriation efforts worldwide and directly informed later legal frameworks such as the U.S. Native American Graves Protection and Repatriation Act.

The revival of Tribal Canoe Journeys since 1989 has likewise become a template studied and adapted by other Indigenous coastal and river peoples internationally, and the potlatch system's core insight — that social status is earned through distribution rather than accumulation — continues to inform Indigenous economic and governance thinking well beyond the Northwest Coast itself.

The Potlatch Ban — Controversies and Fairness

On January 1, 1885, the Canadian government amended the Indian Act to criminalize the potlatch outright, motivated by the view — held by missionaries, Indian agents, and federal officials alike — that the practice was incompatible with Christian morality and capitalist economics, encouraged "improvident" giving away of property, and reinforced Indigenous political and spiritual authority that assimilation policy was explicitly designed to dismantle. The law was so vaguely worded that a British Columbia chief justice initially ruled it unenforceable, and for decades enforcement was inconsistent; many communities simply continued potlatching in secret, sometimes disguising ceremonies as Christmas or New Year gatherings.

That changed decisively in December 1921, when Chief Dan Cranmer's potlatch at Village Island drew a large federal crackdown: forty-five arrests, roughly half resulting in jail time, and the confiscation of some six hundred sacred and ceremonial objects that were sold or donated to museums across North America and Europe — a loss whose full recovery remains incomplete more than a century later.

The ban was finally repealed in a 1951 overhaul of the Indian Act, a shift widely understood to reflect the post-war global human-rights reckoning and Canada's own discomfort with the uncomfortable parallel between its assimilationist legislation and the racial policies just defeated in the Second World War. Chief Mungo Martin held the first fully legal potlatch in 1953.

The confiscation and its aftermath remain a live and unsettled issue: some objects have been repatriated to U'mista and other community-run cultural centres, but a substantial number remain in museum and private collections whose institutions have been slow, or in some cases unwilling, to return them. A second, ongoing controversy concerns the commercial and decorative use of Northwest Coast crest imagery and totem-pole forms by non-Indigenous artists, municipalities, and businesses outside their originating families and nations — a practice increasingly challenged by Indigenous artists and legal scholars as a form of appropriation that treats sacred, family-owned property as generic regional decoration. Contemporary fishing and land-rights disputes — over treaty-protected salmon harvests, pipeline routes through unceded territory, and title claims — remain a further active front, tying the historical suppression of ceremony directly to present-day questions of sovereignty and resource access.

Closing

The potlatch ban is gone from the law books, but its sixty-six years left scars that repatriation and revival are still working through — masks still sitting in foreign museum vaults, songs whose owners were jailed for singing them.

And still the canoes go out every summer, and still the coppers keep their names, and still a chief's grandson learns, cedar bark in hand, what it means to give until it means something.

Grand rising to the peoples of cedar and salt water — this account continues as their nations do.